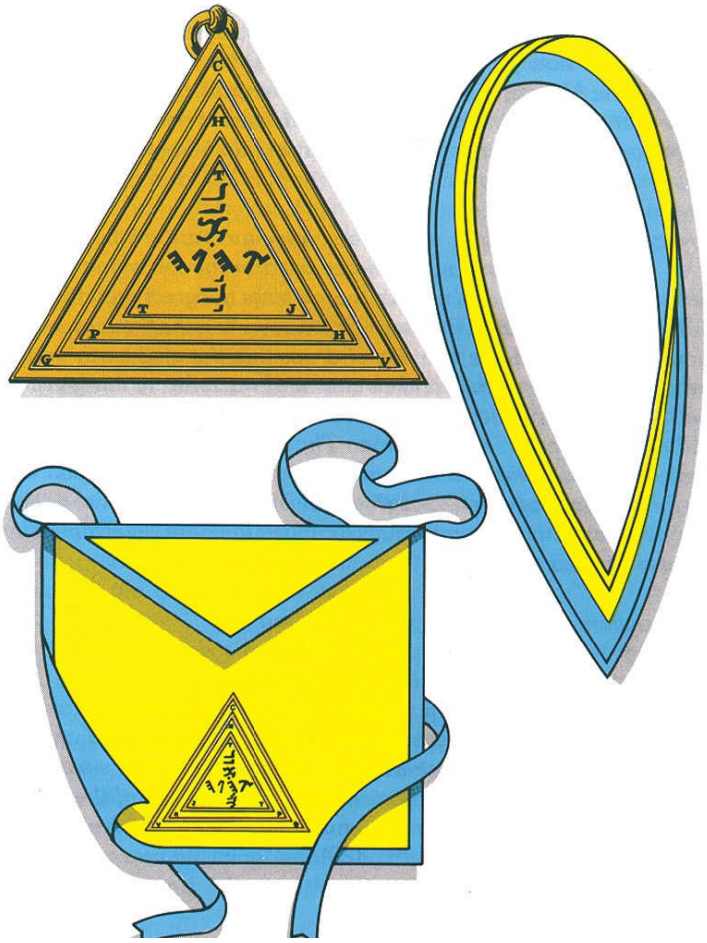
The 20th Degree – Master of the Symbolic Lodge



The apron is yellow, bordered and lined with sky–blue. In the center are three concentric equilateral triangles, with the initial letters of the nine Great Lights in the corners. The letters stand for the following: Charity, Generosity, Veneration, Heroism, Patriotism, Honor, Toleration, Truth and Justice. In the center of the inner Triangle is the Tetragrammaton in Phoenician characters. Intersecting it vertically are the Hebrew words *yehi aur* (יהי אור) “Let there be light” (Gen. 1:3).

The cordon is a broad ribbon of yellow and sky–blue; it may also be two ribbons, one of each color, crossing each other.

The jewel is gold, like the triangles on the apron, with the same words and letters.

DUTIES

Dispense light and knowledge.
Practice the Masonic virtues both in and out of the lodge.

LESSONS

Truth, justice and toleration are indispensable qualities for a Master of the Lodge.
Example is the best teaching method known.

FOR REFLECTION

Is your behavior the same both in and out of lodge?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Triangle, square, octagon, candles, three pillars, Pythagorean right triangle.

Over the many years that the ceremonies of the Scottish Rite have been performed, many acceptable changes, additions, and minor deletions have been made. The Rubric (a text of acceptable modifications) says of this degree:

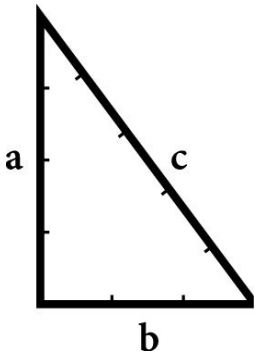
> *The 20th Degree is a most beautiful Degree; conferred in full, including the opening and closing, it presents the lessons of the Degree in pure, classical drama, scarcely excelled anywhere. Nothing should be added, and nothing subtracted. Finish the Degree according to our Ritual. Do not spoil it by introducing a single thing. (p. 10)*

This degree is considered classical drama for many reasons. The most significant are its simplicity in set and action, the ceremonial use of candles, and the use of squares, triangles, and pillars, the classic symbols of Masonry. In *Morals and Dogma,* Pike notes that Masonry should be returned to its primitive purity. (p. 325) The ceremony is a dramatic statement of this “primitive purity.”

CEREMONY

The hangings are blue and gold, signifying the blue and gold of the clouds in which God appeared to Moses. The number nine, the triangle and the square figure prominently in the set.

Nine is a perfect number, being the triple of three. There are nine candles in three groups of three each on the East, West and South of the Altar. They form a graphic representation of the 47th Problem of Euclid, also called the Pythagorean Theorem, after Pythagoras, an ancient Greek philosopher and geometrician. It demonstrates that in all right triangles the sum of the squares of the two sides which form a right angle and the square of the side opposite the right angle are equal. If each side is labeled as shown, a, b, and c, the equation is $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$.



This relationship between the length of the sides does not vary among any of the right triangles; that is, a triangle with one angle of 90 degrees or one corner formed by the intersection of perpendicular lines. It makes no difference in the equation if the other two angles are 45 degrees each or 30 degrees and 60 degrees or 5 degrees and 85 degrees. Because of the mystic meaning associated with numbers by the ancients, they considered the most beautiful triangle of all, the right angled triangle with sides of 3, 4 and 5 units of measure.

In the middle of the lodge room are three columns, forming a triangle. On the column in the East is written “Truth,” on that in the West, “Justice” and on that in the South, “Toleration.”

The Tracing Board shows an octagon, an eight sided figure. It has a square raised on each of five sides and an equilateral triangle on each of the remaining three sides. In the corners of the triangles and squares are the initials of the twenty–nine virtues of a Mason. The octagon is the intermediate geometric form between the square and the circle. The circle is a symbol of the number one, of heaven and the eternal or spiritual; the square is a symbol of the earth, the

terrestrial or earthly. The symbolic meaning of the octagon derives from the practice of the ancients of “squaring the circle.” Their goal was to obtain unity in the material world and in the spiritual life. One way of squaring the circle was to superimpose two squares, inscribing a circle within in such a way as to form an octagon. Hence, the octagon represents the path indicated by the square towards the circle; that is, the path from the earthly life to perfection, from matter to spirit. The other shape on the Tracing Board, the triangle, represents the aspiration of all things to the higher Unity or the spiritual. The practice of the twenty–nine Masonic virtues is the path to perfection of both the earthly and the spiritual natures of man. A Master of the Symbolic Lodge is a leader and a teacher; his life should exemplify the path of Masonic virtue.

First Section

When the candidate enters the Lodge, the nine candles on the altar are not lit. Standing within the three columns of Toleration, Justice and Truth, the candidate learns these three great principles which support the Masonic fraternity.

Being raised to Master of the Symbolic Lodge, the candidate receives instruction on the duties of this position. The nine candles are lit one by one by the candidate, an act symbolic of the Master’s duty: to incorporate within himself and to dispense the light and knowledge associated with the nine great lights in Masonry—veneration, charity, generosity, heroism, honor, patriotism, justice, toleration and truth.

The final instruction identifies the twenty–nine virtues represented by the letters on the five great squares and three great triangles surrounding the octagon on the Tracing Board. On the squares they are: prudence, temperance, chastity and sobriety; heroism, firmness, equanimity and zeal; probity, honor, fidelity and punctuality; disinterestedness, lenity, forgiveness and forbearance; and charity, kindness, generosity and liberality. On the triangles they are: gratitude to God, love of mankind and confidence in human nature; veneration of God, devotedness to family and friends, and patriotism, described as ardent love for

our country. The greatest of all the virtues appear on the triangle in the top center of the octagon: truth, justice and toleration.

Second Section

The hall is brilliant with light. The Master is called the President, and Senior and Junior Wardens are his Counselors. Stationed in the room are representatives of nine sage lawgivers: Zarathustra (Zoroaster), Manu, Hermes, Confucius, Moses, Hammurabi, Numa, Alfred and finally, Socrates who completes the nine but whose words are spoken by someone else.

Beginning with the Persian lawgiver Zarathustra, the candidate learns that the evil intentions of the criminal are the true measure of crime and not the events which follow it.

Manu, the ancient legislator of the Aryans of India, counsels that one should read the sacred books, practice charity, sacrifice to the gods, become not the slave of the pleasures of the senses, be merciful to dumb animals, seek not revenge, judge men leniently and forgive easily.

Hermes, whom the Egyptians called “Thoth” and the Romans, “Mercury,” assures the candidate that the gods do not judge harshly those they created weak and with little wisdom.

Confucius states that he has read and interpreted the great laws engraved by the finger of God upon the Book of Nature.

Moses recites some of his own sayings and affirms that he was initiated into the Mysteries and wisdom of ancient Egypt (Acts 7:22) and that from the Lord he received the wisdom to dictate those statues by which he governed Israel.

Hammurabi, the lawgiver of Babylonians, affirms that the laws he gave were developments of the infinite justice to which all men should inspire, and that we should act with moderation, equity and integrity.

Numa, first king of the Romans, repeats what he said to the Roman people, “Desire not for your country any other benefit than Justice. Justice is Equity—to render to every man that to which he is entitled. Let doubt of guilt be acquittal and presumption of innocence, solid proof.”

Alfred the Great testifies that he caused just and speedy judgment to be given and that he reigned only to bless those over whom his dominion extended.

The President says that Socrates claimed that when he sat in the Court of the Areopagus he swore to give sentences uprightly, receiving neither gifts nor bribes. Such a disclaimer was necessary in a place and time of great corruption. The President also warns against hasty, improper and uncharitable judgment.

LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma* Pike is very direct and practical in his explanation of the duties of a Master of the Symbolic Lodge. He refers to a special duty, to aid in restoring Masonry to its primitive purity (p. 325) so that it is not an object of ridicule or humiliating to candidates, as was the case during a part of its history.

The selections which follow do not contain all of the qualities, virtues and attitudes which should be learned and practiced by the Master of the Symbolic Lodge. Pike lists too many for this summary. This lecture, in its entirety, is especially recommended. It should be noted that in *Morals and Dogma*, Pike uses the title “Grand Master of All Symbolic Lodges” in lieu of that used in this summary.

Duties of a Master of the Symbolic Lodge:

The true Mason is a practical Philosopher, who, under religious emblems, in all ages adopted by wisdom, builds upon plans traced by nature and reason the moral edifice of knowledge. He ought to find, in the symmetrical relation of all the parts of this rational edifice, the principle and rule of all his duties, the source of all his pleasures. He improves his moral nature, becomes a better man, and finds in the reunion of virtuous men, assembled with pure views, the means of multiplying his acts of beneficence (p. 325).

As Grand Master of all Symbolic Lodges, it is your especial duty to aid in restoring Masonry to its primitive purity. You have become an instructor (p. 325).

We teach the truth of none of the legends we recite. They are to us but parables

and allegories, involving and enveloping Masonic instruction; and vehicles of useful and interesting information. They represent the different phases of the human mind, its efforts and struggles to comprehend nature, God, the government of the Universe, the permitted existence of sorrow and evil. ... Every one being at liberty to apply our symbols and emblems as he thinks most consistent with truth and reason and with his own faith, we give them such an interpretation only as may be accepted by all (p. 329).

Thus the Initiates are inspired with a just idea of Masonry, to wit, that it is essentially WORK; both teaching and practising LABOR; and that it is altogether emblematic. Three kinds of work are necessary to the preservation and protection of man and society: manual labor, specially belonging to the three Blue Degrees; labor in arms, symbolized by the Knightly or chivalric Degrees; and intellectual labor, belonging particularly to the Philosophical Degrees (p. 331).

Especially you are not to allow any assembly of the body over which you may preside, to close, without recalling to the minds of the Brethren the Masonic virtues and duties which are represented upon the Tracing Board of this Degree. That is an imperative duty. Forget not that, more than three thousand years ago, ZOROASTER said: “Be good, be kind, be human, and charitable; love your fellows; console the afflicted; pardon those who have done you wrong.”... CONFUCIUS repeated ...: “Love thy neighbor as thyself: Forgive injuries, Forgive your enemy, be reconciled to him, give him assistance, invoke God in his behalf! (p. 333).

Urge them to love one another, to be devoted to one another, to be faithful to the country, the government and the laws: for to serve the country is to pay a dear and sacred debt:

To respect all forms of worship, to tolerate all political and religious opinions; ...:

To fraternize with all men; to assist all who are unfortunate; and to cheerfully postpone their own interests to that of the Order: To make it the constant rule of their lives, to think well, to speak well, and to act well:

To place the sage above the soldier, the noble, or the prince: and take the wise and good as their models:

To see that their professions and practice, their teachings and conduct, do always agree:

To make this also their motto: Do that which thou oughtest to do; let the result be what it will (p. 333).

“Have you seen your Master today?”

The *frontispiece* for Pike’s old Consistory Ritual shows an Egyptian figure with the words:

“Have you seen your Master today?”
“I have.”
“How is he clothed?”
“In blue and gold.”



The figure shown is that of Horus and is incorrect. It should be the figure of Thoth as shown on the left. This figure is reproduced here because the Egyptian Thoth is their equivalent of the Grecian Hermes and the Roman Mercury, the true Grand Master of All Symbolic Lodges. From the earliest Masonic manuscripts we see Hermes represented as the ideal of the Master of the Lodge and in some traditions is even said to be the founder of Masonry. Pike, in his

Second Lecture on Masonic Symbolism (p. 262) makes the following observation.

> *The "Master, clothed in blue and gold," of the Masons of a century and a half ago [1710], was Hermes; and Hermes and Mercury were the same. He is the "Master of the Lodge," associated with the Sun and Moon ....*[1]

The reference to "Masons of a century and a half ago" is clearer when we examine the old catechisms; here is a sample excerpted from the Dumfries No. 4 manuscript (1710) printed in Knoop, Jones and Hamer's *Early Masonic Catechisms* (p. 63):

Q: what is a mason? A: he is a worker in stone. Q: would you know your master if you saw him? A: yes. Q: what way would ye know him? A: by his habit. Q: what couller is his habit? A: yellow and blew meaning the compass [which] is bras and Iron (punctuation added for clarity; spelling is as in the original).

This digression into Masonic history has a point. Both historical and mythical figures are used in Masonry as examples of particular conduct. The character of Hiram in the Symbolic Lodge teaches us steadfastness in the face of adversity. In this case the recipient of this degree is taught by the example of Hermes to love knowledge and to teach others the result of his efforts.

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1. Rex R. Hutchens, ed., *Albert Pike's Lecture on Masonic Symbolism and A Second Lecture on Symbolism: The Omkara and Other Ineffable Words* (Washington: Scottish Rite Research Society, 2006), p. II.170. For more on the relationship between Hermes and the master of the lodge, see Arturo de Hoyos, ed., *Albert Pike's Esoterika: Symbolism of the Blue Degrees of Freemasonry* (Washington: Scottish Rite Research Society, 2005), pp. 103–6.